

The 10 Things Recruiters Check in 6 Seconds

A CV Checklist by Lodestar

Most CVs are rejected before they're read. Recruiters spend an average of 6 seconds on a first scan. Here's exactly what they're looking at — and what you need to nail every single time.

01

A Clear, Scannable Layout

Recruiters don't read — they scan. No tables, no text boxes, no multi-column layouts that confuse ATS. Clean margins, clear hierarchy, white space that breathes.

→ *Can someone find your name, title, and last role in under 2 seconds?*

02

A Job Title That Matches the Role

Your current or most recent job title appears near the top. If it doesn't match what they're hiring for, add a one-line positioning statement below your name.

→ *"Product Manager" not "Delivery Excellence Specialist" unless that's the exact role title.*

03

Quantified Impact, Not Duties

Every bullet should answer: so what? Reduced onboarding time by 40%. Managed a €2M budget. Led a team of 8. Numbers make vague claims real.

→ *Replace 'responsible for' with 'delivered', 'led', 'reduced', 'increased', 'launched'.*

04

Relevant Keywords in the Right Places

Recruiters search for keywords before reading. Your CV must mirror the exact phrases from the job description — in your title, summary, and experience bullets.

→ *Copy the JD. Highlight every skill/tool. Make sure yours matches.*

05

A Professional Email Address

This sounds obvious but it still costs people interviews. `firstname.lastname@gmail.com` is the standard.

→ *Use a custom domain email if you have one — it signals professionalism.*

06

Dates in the Right Format

Month-Year to Month-Year. Every role. No unexplained gaps — recruiters flag anything that feels like it's hiding something.

→ *For gaps: a short honest line beats a suspicious blank.*

07

No More Than 2 Pages

Unless you have 15+ years of directly relevant experience, 2 pages is your ceiling. 1 page if you're early career.

→ *3 pages? Cut the oldest or least relevant roles — not the whitespace.*

08

A LinkedIn URL That Works

Your LinkedIn link should be customized (linkedin.com/in/yourname) and consistent with your CV. A dead link raises questions.

→ *Settings > Edit public profile > Edit URL. Takes 30 seconds.*

09

No Generic Objective Statements

'Seeking a challenging role to grow my skills' is wasted space. Replace it with a 2-line positioning statement: who you are, what you deliver, for whom.

→ *Example: 'PM with 5 years in fintech, specializing in 0-to-1 products and cross-functional delivery.'*

10

File Name and Format

Save as FirstName-LastName-CV.pdf. Not MyCV_Final_v3_REAL.docx. PDF preserves your formatting across every device.

→ *Always send PDF unless the job posting specifically asks for Word.*

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Find your direction. Own your story.

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